Proliferation pessimists also highlight the war-proneness of military regimes because of the putative offensive bias of most military organizations.[1] Neither the Soviet Union nor the People's Republic of China was a military regime. However, they were regimes with professedly revolutionary ideologies and hardly averse to the use of force in international politics.[2] Nevertheless, they displayed exemplary restraint when involved in an acute international crisis. For example, the Soviet Union and the People's Republic of China were embroiled in a territorial dispute along the Ussuri River in the late 1960s. At that time, both states possessed nuclear arsenals, although the Chinese arsenal was in its incipient stages.[3] This territorial dispute erupted into war in March 1969 and resulted in considerable loss of life.[4] However, it did not escalate into full-scale war and the conflict was brought to a close through bilateral negotiations.

The Ussuri River clashes and their resolution demonstrate that two revolutionary states with risk-prone political leaderships can nevertheless exercise restraint and prevent the onset of a conflict spiral. More to the point, the Soviets who had significantly greater nuclear capabilities, chose not to carry out a preemptive strike on Chinese nuclear forces.[5] Admittedly, the Ussuri River conflict constitutes a single case. Nevertheless, it is emblematic of the restraint that was evinced in the midst of a significant border conflict. Consequently, it does not appear unreasonable to argue that similar restraint will ensue in the Indo-Pakistani context. Ultimately, minimally rational national leaders are, above all, interested in national survival. Consequently, they recognize the dramatic destructive powers of nuclear weapons and conclude that no possible political goal can be accomplished through their use, especially when their adversaries possess similar capabilities. Such a realization in turn induces substantial caution when in the midst of a crisis for fear of inadvertent or uncontrolled escalation to the nuclear level. Consequently, governments have every incentive to circumscribe the scope and dimensions of the conflict. In effect, this analysis reaffirms the central logic of rational deterrence theory: namely, that the sheer destructive potential of nuclear weapons forces even risk-prone decision makers to avoid provoking or